

Title Changes Meaning Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 20-30 min

Category	The Arts	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	title-changes-meaning

Big idea: Context changes interpretation.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Title Changes Meaning Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Title Changes Meaning Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: The same image titled 'Waiting', 'Evidence', 'Aftermath', and 'Home'. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Title Changes Meaning Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Students interpret before and after seeing titles. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Title Changes Meaning Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A title-writing round where students try to control audience interpretation. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Context changes interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Title Changes Meaning Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Title Changes Meaning Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Does the artist control the meaning of an artwork?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- The same image titled 'Waiting', 'Evidence', 'Aftermath', and 'Home'.
- Students interpret before and after seeing titles.
- A title-writing round where students try to control audience interpretation.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to The Arts.

Activity Steps

1. Show the same image with Title A. Students write a one-sentence interpretation.
2. Repeat with Title B and Title C.
3. Students compare how their interpretation changed.
4. Discuss whether the title revealed meaning or created it.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Does the artist control the meaning of an artwork?
- Can interpretation be wrong?
- What kind of knowledge can art provide?

Knowledge Questions

- Does the artist control the meaning of an artwork?
- Can interpretation be wrong?
- What kind of knowledge can art provide?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with the same image titled 'waiting', 'evidence', 'aftermath', and 'home'. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...